Navier-Stokes

OpenAI's fight with a mathematician on who solved the impossible equation

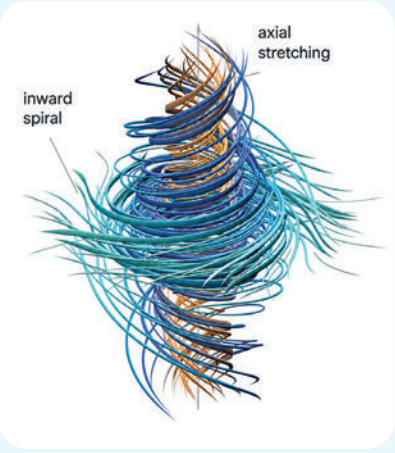
—By **Vyom Ramani**

Generative AI and AI companies have been viewed as the public enemy since ChatGPT first came out back in 2022 and credit where it is due, the companies have managed to maintain that reputation really well through the years. Case in point: back in July 2026, OpenAI announced it was giving academics and researchers free access to its frontier models to accelerate scientific discovery, a well-meaning initiative on paper. Except, like most things OpenAI does, it got picked apart on X within hours. One reply to the announcement on X, laid out a theory – that the real play was to let researchers do the early legwork on a capped compute budget, then finish and publish the work internally once the ideas were harvested, unlimited compute and all.

The math, briefly

OpenAI has released a statement from September 8, declaring that an internal model, which is more advanced than GPT-6 Astra, generated a proof, which was formally verified in Lean, that the Navier-Stokes equations (describing fluid motion and one of the seven Clay Institute Millennium Prize Problems) can produce a singularity in a finite amount of time under smooth forcing.

OpenAI's post congratulates Tristan Buckmaster and Anthropic researcher



Levent Alpöge for a "remarkable mathematical achievement," for a related, separate proof of forced 3D Euler blowup, and says that no user data was accessed to solve the problem, while admitting it "cannot rule out" that de-identified usage data may have helped.

Buckmaster's version

Buckmaster and Alpöge spent nearly a year working with Claude, Codex and GPT-5.6/Astra on a forced Navier-Stokes blowup solution. After reports suggested Anthropic had solved a major unsolved problem, Buckmaster contacted OpenAI's Sébastien Bubeck, who said OpenAI's internal model had independently produced a 100-page proof using similar approaches. Buckmaster later learned the model had received extensive human guidance, including warm-up tasks and carefully constructed prompts. He also says OpenAI did not clarify whether the model had accessed his private Codex sessions. Buckmaster alleges he was pressured over publication by Bubeck.

Bubeck's rebuttal

Bubeck disputes Buckmaster's account, saying authorship concerns involved whether an Anthropic employee could co-author OpenAI's rewritten Navier-Stokes proof, not removing Alpöge. He says the controversial remarks came after being accused of slander and told, "I simply do not trust you." **tinyurl.com/dvty3vf2**

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